

Sudan Civil War (2023–Present)

Overview

The Sudan Civil War is an ongoing armed conflict that began on **15 April 2023** between the **Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF)** and the **Rapid Support Forces (RSF)**. What started as a power struggle between two military leaders quickly escalated into one of the world's largest humanitarian crises, affecting millions of civilians and devastating Sudan's economy, infrastructure, healthcare system, and social fabric. ([Reuters](#))

Background

Sudan has experienced decades of political instability, military coups, and civil wars.

Key Historical Events

1956

- Sudan gained independence from Britain and Egypt.

1955–1972

- First Sudanese Civil War between the northern government and southern rebels.

1983–2005

- Second Sudanese Civil War.
- Over **2 million people** were killed.
- Led to the independence of **South Sudan** in 2011.

1989

- Military officer **Omar al-Bashir** seized power through a coup.

2003–2020

- Conflict in Darfur resulted in hundreds of thousands of deaths and widespread displacement.

2019

- Massive nationwide protests forced President Omar al-Bashir from power after nearly 30 years in office.

2021

- Sudan's military leaders staged another coup, ending the civilian-led transitional government.

2023

- Disagreements over integrating the RSF into the national army triggered open warfare on **15 April 2023**. ([Reuters](#))
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Main Parties to the Conflict

Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF)

- Sudan's national military.
 - Commander:
 - General **Abdel Fattah al-Burhan**
 - Controls much of eastern Sudan and key government institutions.
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Rapid Support Forces (RSF)

- Powerful paramilitary organization.
 - Commander:
 - General **Mohamed Hamdan Dagalo ("Hemedti")**
 - Originated from the Janjaweed militias active during the Darfur conflict.
 - Controls much of Darfur and other contested regions. ([Reuters](#))
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Causes of the War

1. Power Struggle

After the 2021 military coup, both military leaders agreed to a civilian transition but disagreed over who would ultimately control Sudan.

2. Integration of the RSF

One major disagreement concerned whether the RSF should:

- merge into the national army,
- remain independent,
- or how long integration should take.

Neither side trusted the other.

3. Competition for Political Power

Both military leaders sought control over:

- national government
- military command
- state resources
- future elections

4. Economic Interests

Both factions control lucrative businesses involving:

- gold mining
- border trade
- transportation
- banking
- foreign investments

Economic competition intensified political tensions.

5. Weak Democratic Institutions

Years of military rule left Sudan with:

- weak government institutions
- limited civilian oversight
- fragile security structures

These weaknesses made violent conflict more likely. ([Reuters](#))

Major Areas Affected

The conflict has spread across much of Sudan, particularly:

- Khartoum
- North Darfur

- South Darfur
- West Darfur
- El Fasher
- North Kordofan
- South Kordofan
- Blue Nile

Many towns have experienced repeated fighting and displacement. ([World Health Organization](#))

Humanitarian Impact

The conflict has become one of the world's largest humanitarian emergencies.

Population in Need

Approximately:

- **34 million people** require humanitarian assistance.
 - Around **21 million** need urgent health assistance.
 - Roughly **75% of the population** requires some form of aid. ([The United Nations in Sudan](#))
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Displacement

Sudan has become the world's largest displacement crisis.

Estimated figures include:

- nearly **13 million** people forced from their homes,
 - over **10 million** internally displaced,
 - more than **3 million** refugees in neighboring countries. ([UNHCR](#))
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Death Toll

Determining the exact number of deaths is difficult because many areas remain inaccessible.

Current estimates include:

- at least **59,000 confirmed deaths**, though experts believe the real toll is much higher,
 - some independent analyses suggest the total may be in the **hundreds of thousands** when indirect deaths from hunger, disease, and lack of healthcare are considered. ([AP News](#))
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Children

Children have been heavily affected through:

- interrupted education
- severe malnutrition
- disease outbreaks
- displacement
- recruitment by armed groups
- psychological trauma

More than **17 million children** require humanitarian assistance. ([UNICEF](#))

Women and Girls

Women face increased risks of:

- sexual violence
- forced marriage
- gender-based violence
- limited maternal healthcare

Millions remain at risk due to the collapse of protection services. ([United Nations Population Fund](#))

Health Situation

The conflict has severely weakened Sudan's health system.

Major challenges include:

- destruction of hospitals

- shortages of medicines
- attacks on healthcare workers
- disease outbreaks
- malnutrition
- lack of clean water

Reported disease outbreaks include:

- Cholera
 - Malaria
 - Measles
 - Dengue
 - Hepatitis E
 - Meningitis
 - Polio ([The United Nations in Sudan](#))
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Food Security

The war has disrupted agriculture and markets.

Consequences include:

- widespread food shortages
- rising food prices
- famine conditions in some regions
- millions experiencing acute hunger

Agricultural production has fallen because farmers have fled conflict zones and supply chains have been disrupted. ([AP News](#))

Economic Impact

The conflict has caused:

- destruction of infrastructure
- closure of businesses

- banking disruptions
- loss of foreign investment
- rising inflation
- unemployment
- reduced government revenue

Much of Sudan's transport, electricity, and water infrastructure has also been damaged.
([AP News](#))

Important Statistics (2026)

Indicator	Estimate
War began	15 April 2023
People needing aid	~34 million
Children needing assistance	~17.3 million
Internally displaced	>10 million
Refugees in neighboring countries	>3 million
Health assistance required	~21 million people
People at risk of gender-based violence	~12.7 million
Confirmed deaths	At least 59,000 (likely an underestimate)

Major Humanitarian Organizations Operating in Sudan

The following organizations provide emergency relief, healthcare, food assistance, protection, and refugee support:

- United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA)
- World Food Programme (WFP)
- United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF)
- World Health Organization (WHO)
- United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR)

- International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC)
 - Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF / Doctors Without Borders)
 - International Rescue Committee (IRC)
 - Norwegian Refugee Council (NRC)
 - Save the Children
 - CARE International
 - Danish Refugee Council (DRC)
 - Mercy Corps ([UNICEF](#))
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Emergency and Humanitarian Contacts

For assistance, updates, or donations, these organizations maintain official emergency information pages:

- **UN OCHA Sudan Response:** <https://www.unocha.org/sudan>
 - **UNHCR Sudan Emergency:** <https://www.unhcr.org/emergencies/sudan-emergency>
 - **UNICEF Sudan:** <https://www.unicef.org/sudan>
 - **WHO Sudan Emergency:** <https://www.who.int/emergencies>
 - **World Food Programme (WFP):** <https://www.wfp.org>
 - **International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC):** <https://www.icrc.org>
 - **Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF):** <https://www.msf.org>
 - **International Rescue Committee (IRC):** <https://www.rescue.org>
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Key Facts

- The conflict began on **15 April 2023**.
- It is primarily a conflict between the **Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF)** and the **Rapid Support Forces (RSF)**.
- Sudan is experiencing one of the world's largest humanitarian and displacement crises.

- Millions of civilians have been displaced, and large areas face severe shortages of food, healthcare, and clean water.
- International organizations continue to call for humanitarian access, protection of civilians, and a negotiated political solution. ([Reuters](#))